The death of Wilhelm Pieck on 12 September 1960 marked the end of an era for the communist old guard. In tribute, Honecker paid homage in Neuer Weg, praising ‘his attitude to the party and his lifelong humility which bear witness to the noble character of our comrade Wilhelm Pieck, to his utter devotion to the cause of the working class.’ Only five days after Pieck’s death, the People’s Chamber abolished the presidency altogether and replaced it with a collective Council of State. Ulbricht became chairman, with six deputies, a secretary and sixteen members reporting to him, thus formally becoming GDR head of state. It had been a busy year for Ulbricht, during the spring he implemented the last stage in the collectivisation of private farms – an effort SED propagandists dubbed ‘The Socialist Spring in the Countryside’. In the event, between March and May, almost 500,000 farmers who had previously worked privately were forced to join production cooperatives. Officially, they remained the owners of their land, but could no longer freely dispose of it. As early as 25 April, Ulbricht declared the ‘liberation of the farmers’ was complete. However, the ‘brutal method’ of collectivisation prompted a rare rebuke from the US State Department which condemned ‘this programme of compulsion which highlights once again the denial of Germans living in the Soviet zone the basic right to self-determination and the completely unrepresentative character of the East German regime’. Furthermore, Washington accused Ulbricht of using methods ranging from ‘massive pressure campaigns to naked force’. The tragic consequence of this change, as in 1952, was many farms literally went to seed. There was a massive increase in fires, which were probably due to arson, and a sizable number of cattle and pigs perished. More seriously, when crop failures due to the weather were reported, the Soviet Union intervened with food aid, including truckloads of butter (which was put back on the ration).

Once more, fed up and exasperated, a high proportion of people from the farming community sought refuge in West Germany, many bitter at quitting a livelihood to which they had given the sweat of their lives. By the end of spring, the exodus rose to over 1,000 a day, the highest number since 1953. Young people, especially graduates, led the charge along with doctors, dentists, chemists, clerks, lawyers, nurses, draftsmen, midwives, cabinetmakers, mechanics and others. Collectively, they were sharply aware of the discrepancy between the grand myth of a socialist paradise promised